Who Shook My Tree?

Hattie Moss

Saltbush Story House

For everyone who has ever hidden
under the covers when the thunder booms.

Who Shook My Tree?
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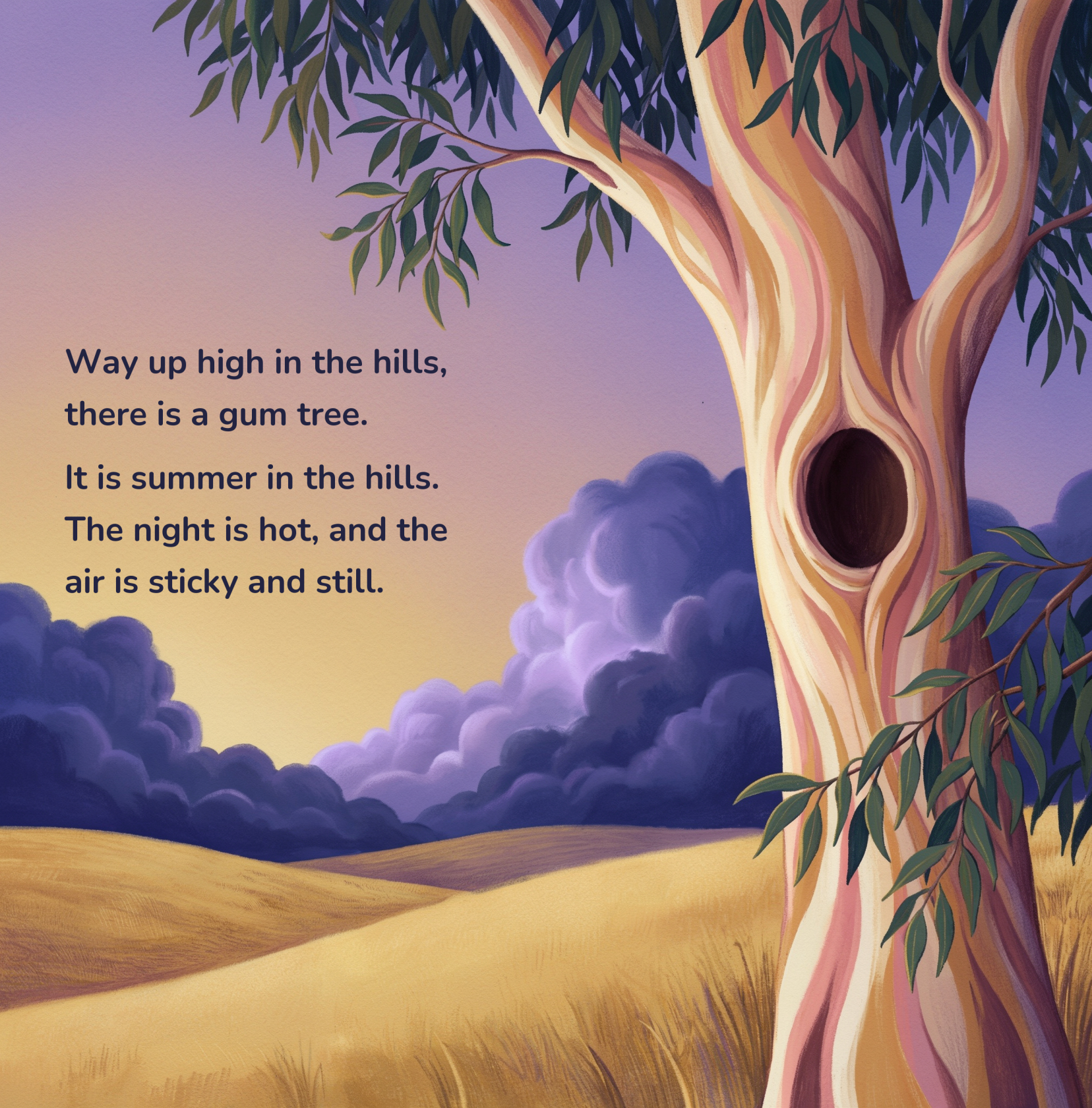


Way up high in the hills,
there is a gum tree.

It is summer in the hills.
The night is hot, and the
air is sticky and still.

Banjo is a sugar glider. He sleeps all day and plays all night.

Tonight, Banjo has a plan: his **BIGGEST** glide ever, right across the gully.

He fluffs his fur.

He wiggles his toes.

He counts. “One. Two. Thr...”

BOOM!

The whole tree SHAKES.
A big white light FLASHES across the bush.
And then everything goes drip.
Drip. DRIP.

Banjo scrambles up to Olive.

"Olive! **OLIVE!** Did you feel that?"

Olive is hugging the trunk, eyes shut. "Mmm. It's a storm, Banjo."

“Storms don’t **SHAKE** trees,” says Banjo. “**SOMEBODY** shook my tree. And I’m going to find out who.”

“Mmm,” says Olive, and hugs her tree a little tighter.

Down at the bottom of the tree, something **RUMBLES**.

It's Wombat!

"Wombat! Did you shake my tree?"

RUMBLE,

goes Wombat's tummy.

"I missed my dinner," says Wombat. "My tummy goes **RUMBLE**. It doesn't go **BOOM**."

"Sorry, Wombat."

FLASH!

For a moment, the whole bush turns white.

Up on a branch, Cockatoo spreads her big white wings.

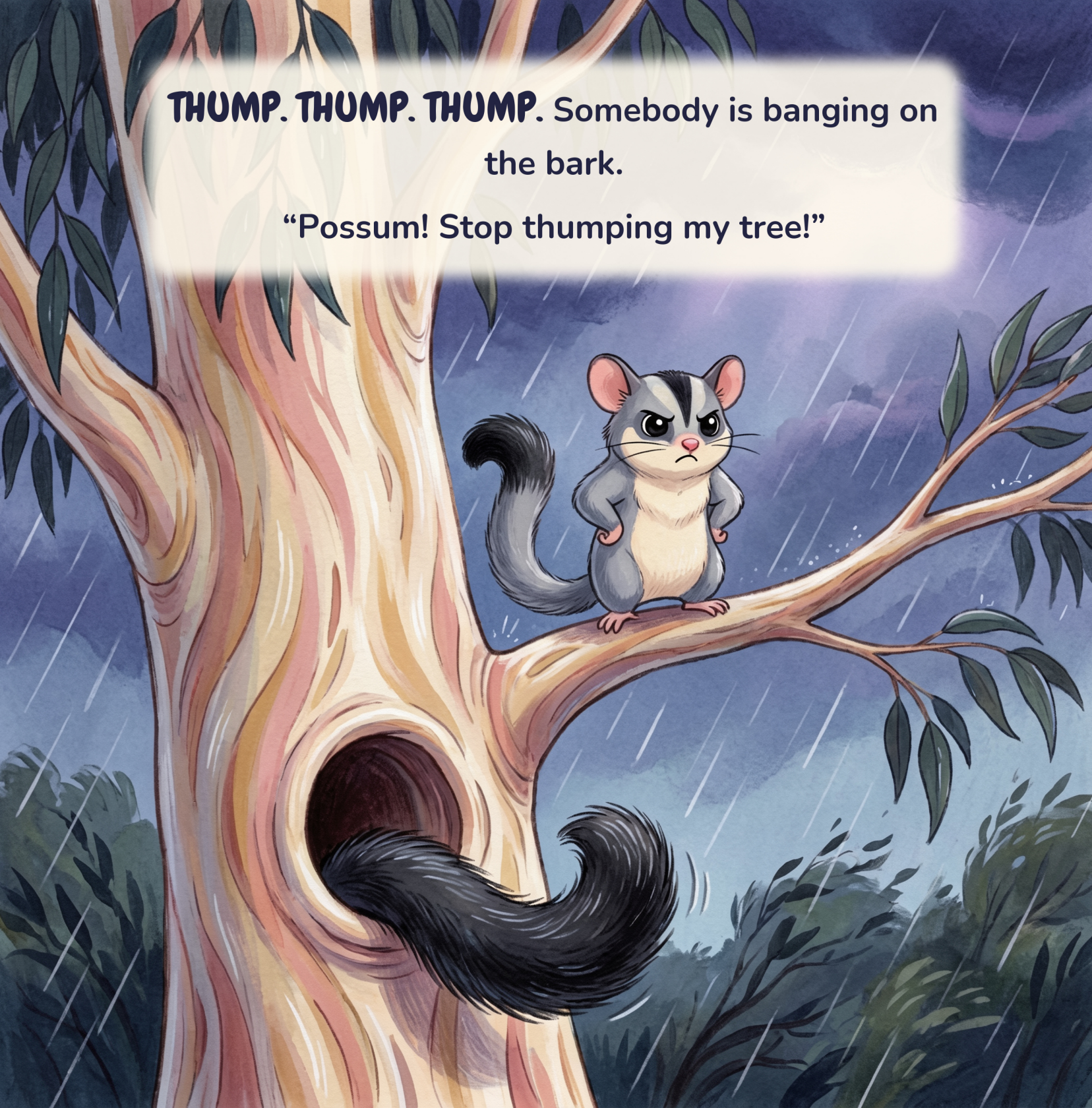
"**AH-HA! YOU** did the **FLASH!**"

SQUAWK!

“I was **STRETCHING**,” says Cockatoo.

She folds her wings. And the sky goes **FLASH** all by itself.

“Sorry, Cockatoo.”


THUMP. THUMP. THUMP. Somebody is banging on the bark.
“Possum! Stop thumping my tree!”

“I’m not thumping,” says Possum, from deep in a hollow.

“I’m **SHAKING**. That **BOOM** is scary!”

Knock, knock, knock, go his knees.

“Sorry, Possum.”

Then the rain comes. Big, fat, splashy drops.
Banjo's fur is wet. His tail is wet. Even his EARS are wet.

“This is serious,” says Banjo.
“Somebody shook my tree
AND made it RAIN on me.”

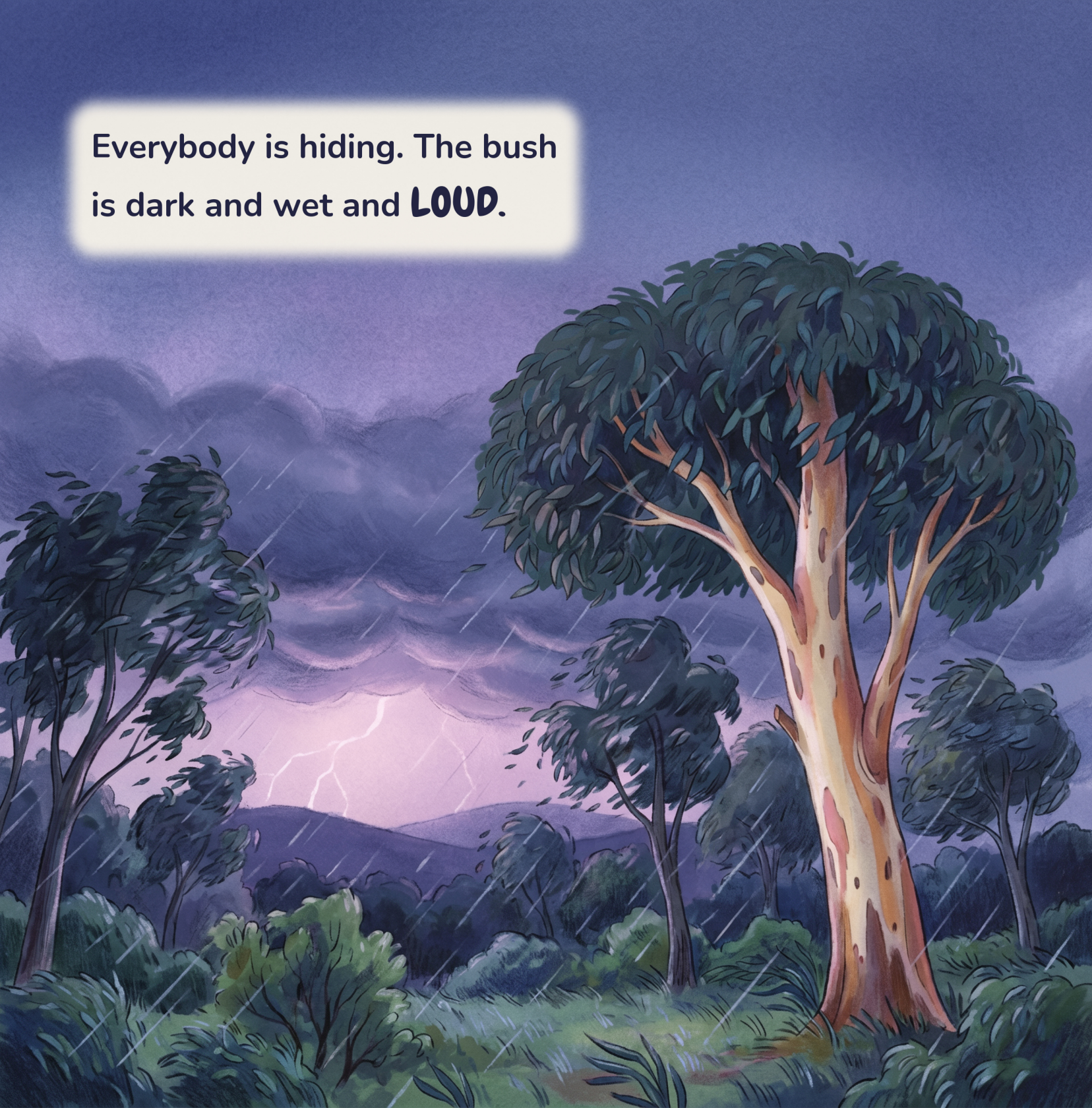
Then, from a low branch, comes a voice.
BOOM!
It's a bird with a long, swirly tail.
"BOOM! BOOM!" "GOTCHA!" shouts Banjo.

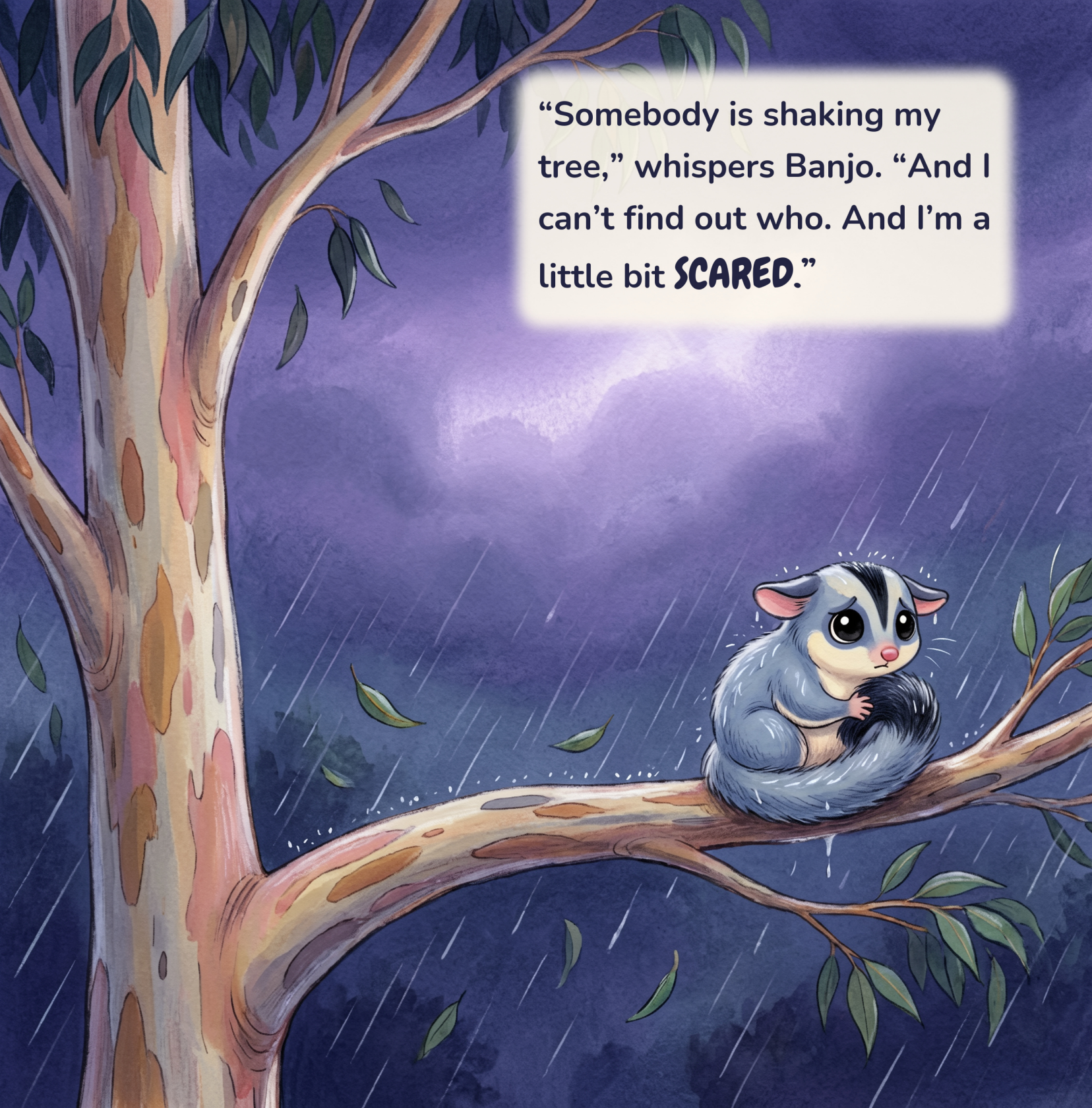
“I’m Lyrebird,” he says. “I copy sounds.”

“**SQUAWK!**” Just like Cockatoo. “**RUMBLE!**” Just like Wombat’s tummy.

“And I copied **BOOM** from the **SKY**.”

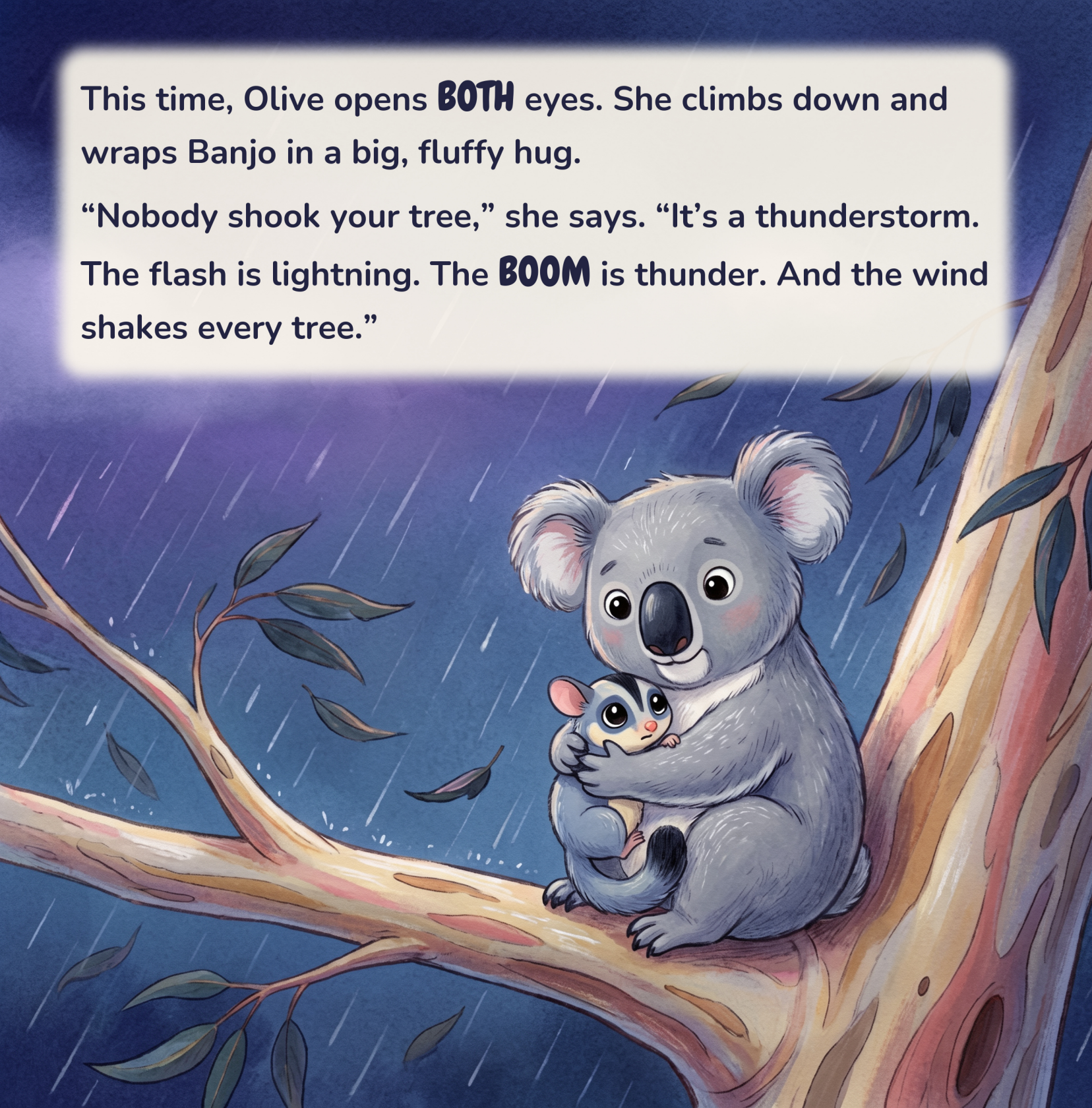
BOOM, goes the sky. Lyrebird’s beak is shut.


Everybody is hiding. The bush is dark and wet and LOUD.


“Somebody is shaking my tree,” whispers Banjo. “And I can’t find out who. And I’m a little bit SCARED.”

This time, Olive opens **BOTH** eyes. She climbs down and wraps Banjo in a big, fluffy hug.

“Nobody shook your tree,” she says. “It’s a thunderstorm. The flash is lightning. The **BOOM** is thunder. And the wind shakes every tree.”



“Here’s a trick,” says Olive. “When you see a flash, count until the **BOOM**.”

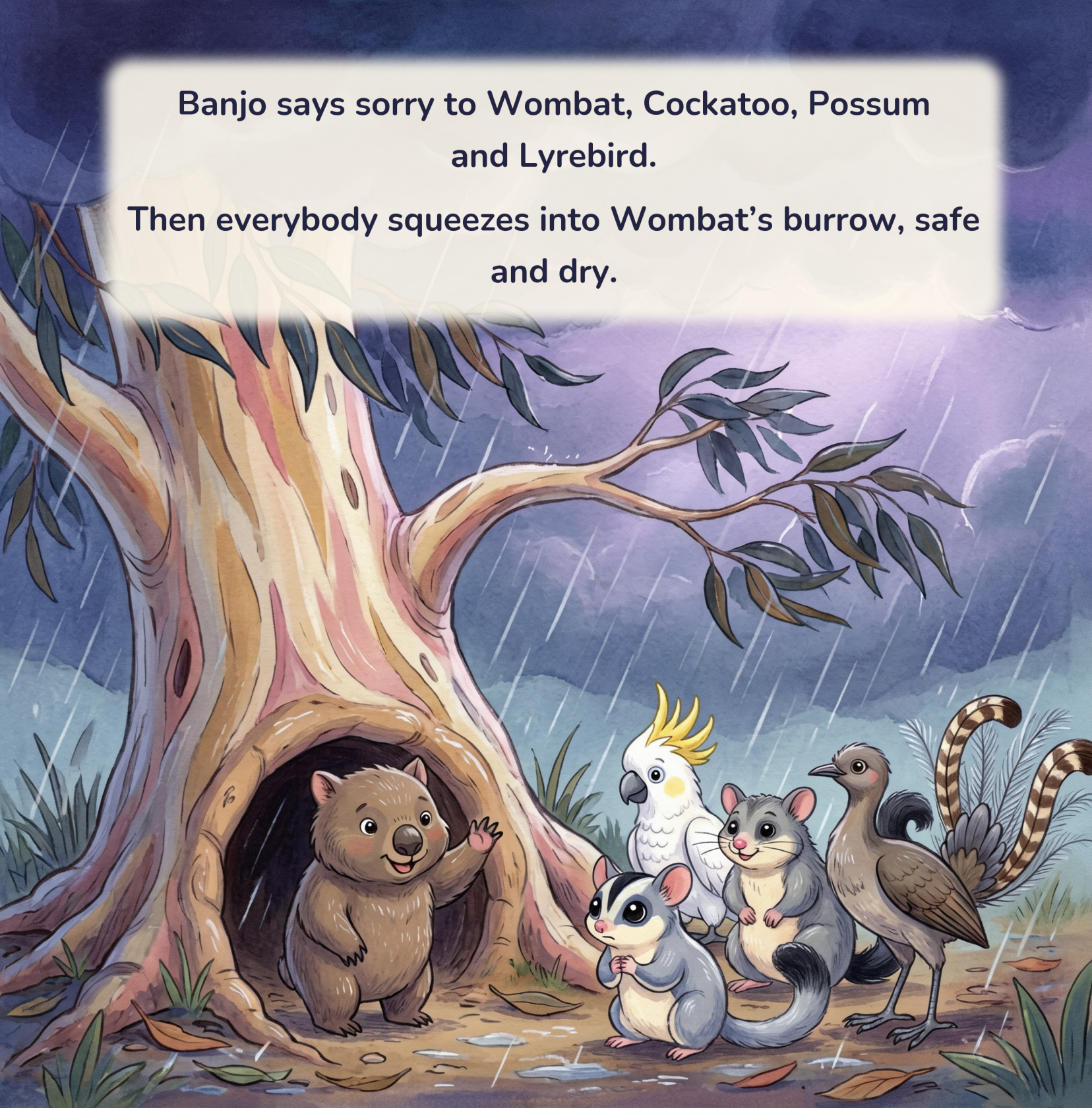
FLASH! “One gum tree, two gum tree…” **BOOM!**

FLASH! “One gum tree, two gum tree, three, four, five…” boom.

“Bigger numbers mean the storm is going away.”

Banjo says sorry to Wombat, Cockatoo, Possum and Lyrebird.

Then everybody squeezes into Wombat's burrow, safe and dry.



Wombat counts on his toes.

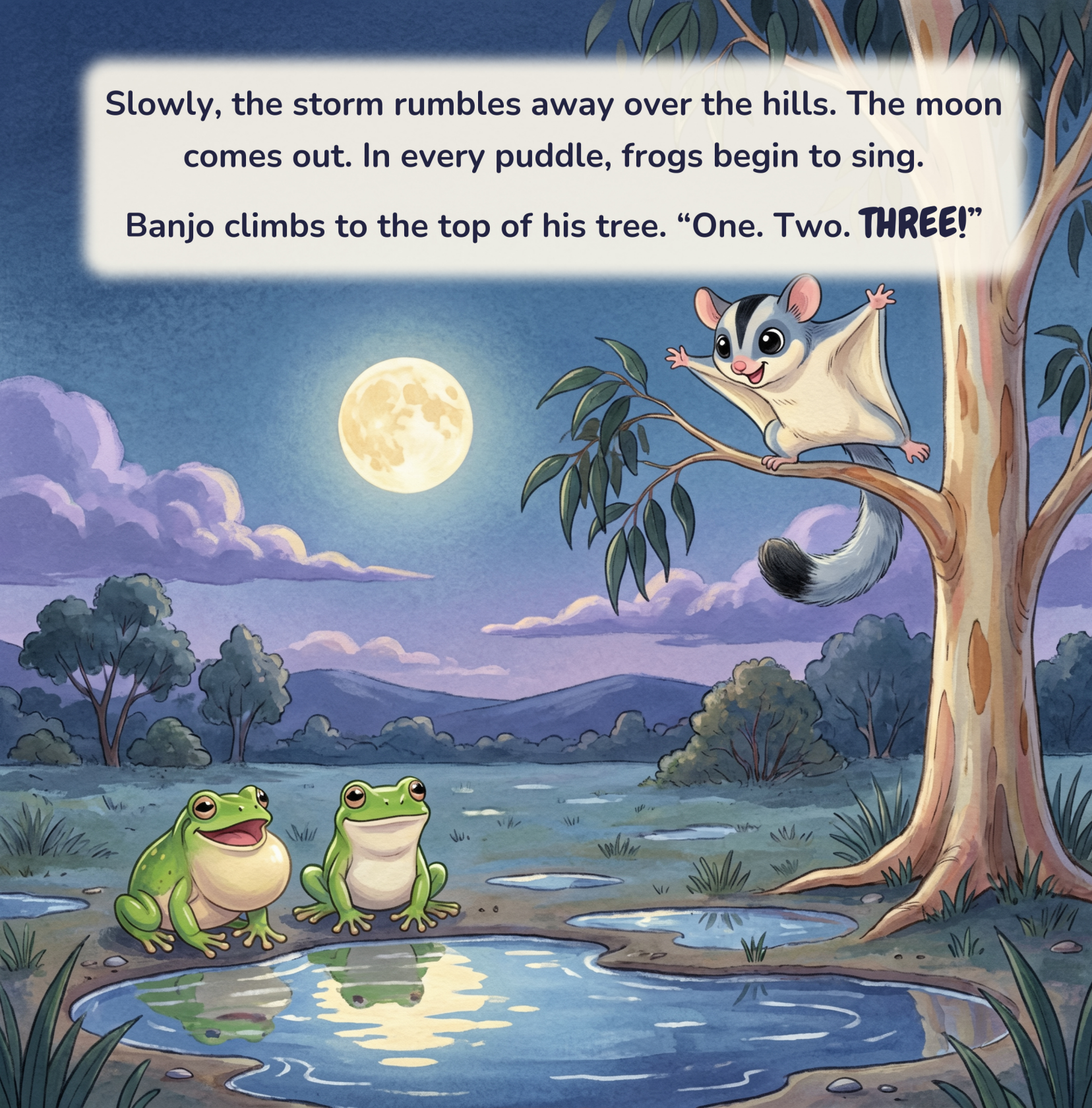
Cockatoo counts on her feathers.

Possum counts with his eyes shut tight.

And Lyrebird counts in Olive's voice.

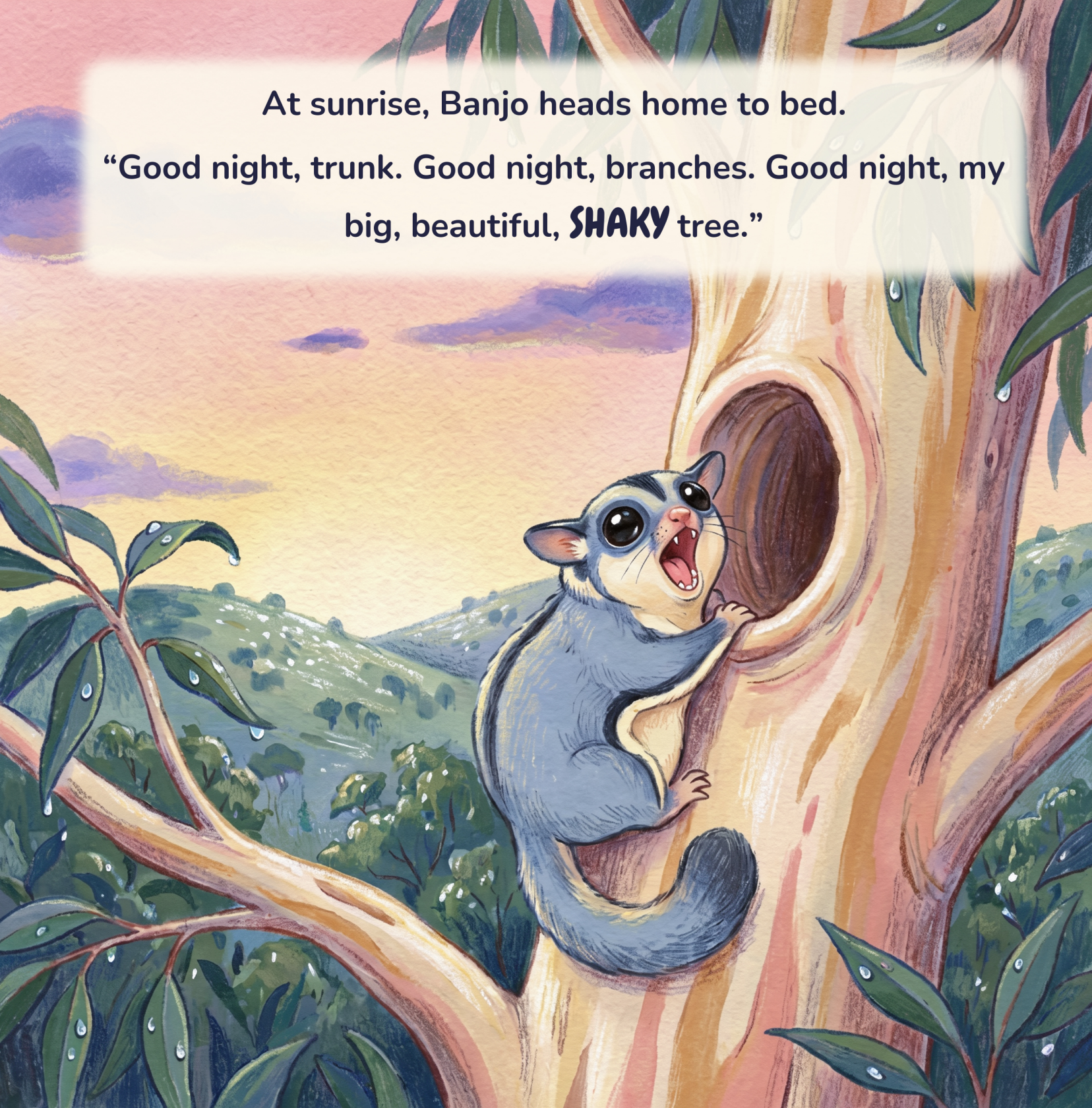
Slowly, the storm rumbles away over the hills. The moon comes out. In every puddle, frogs begin to sing.

Banjo climbs to the top of his tree. “One. Two. **THREE!**”



It’s the **BIGGEST**, swooshiest, sparkliest glide **EVER**, right across the gully!

WHEEE!



At sunrise, Banjo heads home to bed.

"Good night, trunk. Good night, branches. Good night, my big, beautiful, **SHAKY** tree."

RRRUMBLE! The whole tree **SHAKES.**

“Not **AGAIN!**” cries Banjo.

But it isn’t a storm. It’s Olive, snoring.

“**RRRUMBLE,**” says Lyrebird. And he giggles.

True Facts from the Bush

Lightning is a giant spark of electricity in a storm cloud. It heats the air so fast that the air bursts with a BOOM. That BOOM is thunder.

Flash, then boom. Light travels much faster than sound, so you see lightning before you hear thunder. Count the seconds in between: every 5 seconds means the storm is about 1 mile away.

When thunder roars, go indoors. The safest place to watch a storm is from inside.

Superb lyrebirds copy the songs and calls of more than 20 kinds of birds, so well that it's hard to tell them apart. At night they sleep up in the trees.

Green tree frogs call loudly after rain: “crawk, crawk, crawk.”

The smell of rain has a name: petrichor. Two Australian scientists named it in 1964.

Koalas hug tree trunks on hot days, because the trunk is cooler than the air.

Wombats dig long burrows under the ground, where they stay safe and dry.

Sugar gliders sleep in tree hollows lined with leaves, often curled up together in a group.

About the Author

Hattie Moss writes funny picture books about Australian animals. She thinks gum trees are the best trees and sugar gliders are the best gliders.

More Banjo and Olive stories: *Who Peeled My Tree?* and *Who Frosted My Tree?*